PATEL–NEHRU CORRESPONDENCE

(Reproduced from Durga Das [ed.], *Sardar Patel's Correspondence*, Vol. X, pp. 9–22, 335–47.)

1. Jawaharlal Nehru to Sardar Patel, 26 March 1950

My dear Vallabhbhai,

I AM WRITING to you after a great deal of thought, as I feel that I owe it to you and to myself to do so. We have been close friends and colleagues, in spite of differences of opinion, for thirty years or so, and we have passed through numerous crises together. I suppose we have got to know each other fairly well because of this long companionship and working together in all kinds of weather, fair and foul. We have a good deal of affection and respect for each other and this has helped us a great deal in the past to face problems together.

You will remember that some months ago before Gandhiji's death, certain differences of opinion between us were repeatedly discussed before Bapu. In fact, this went on almost to the day of his death. At that time we were faced by a difficult problem. Temperamental differences and differences in viewpoints and approach to certain problems made it a little difficult occasionally for us to pull together. Therefore, the question arose whether it was desirable from the public point of view for those differences of approach to lead to certain consequences which were not good. On the other hand, it was manifest that conditions, as they were in India, demanded that we should pull together and subordinate, to some extent, our personal viewpoints in the interests of the larger good. The problem was a difficult one for us and we took Bapu's advice separately and jointly. Bapu was of opinion for some time that perhaps it was the right course for one of us to retire from Government, leaving the other a free hand. I offered to do so, and so did you. Neither of us, of course, wanted any office or wished any personal equation to affect either our personal relations or public policy. Nevertheless, after repeated discussion we felt, and Bapu appeared to be of